

Friends Scarlett Pope (left) and Ella Venville have both had surgery for scoliosis. Below: X-rays showing the spine before and after surgery. Main photo: Paul Jeffers

20,000 extra uni places to plug skills gap

Adam Carey
Education editor

More than 4000 extra university places will be made available for aspiring teachers, with students from disadvantaged, rural and First Nations backgrounds prioritised as the federal government attempts to turn around a nationwide teacher shortage.

Overall, 20,000 Commonwealth-supported university spots for domestic students will be created in the next two years in areas experiencing skill shortages, including teaching, nursing, IT, health and engineering.

The federal government said the extra places would be made available to students under-represented in universities, including those from poorer backgrounds, First Nations people, and those from rural and remote areas.

The commitment, to be confirmed in this week's federal budget, honours a Labor promise made from opposition in December last year. It will cost up to \$485.5 million over the next four years, with the extra spots made available next year and in 2024.

Education Minister Jason Clare said the additional students would boost the workforce in areas of need.

"This means more teachers, nurses and engineers, and it means more Australians from poor families and rural and remote Australia doing these jobs. That's life-changing," he said.

The budget commitment includes the allocation of 4036 extra education degrees, including 1469 for early education teachers. It also includes 2600 places in nursing, 2275 in IT, 2740 in health professions such as pharmacy and health science, and 1738 in engineering.

Universities put in competitive bids for the Commonwealth-supported degrees, which are paid by the government upfront and paid back by students via HECS.

A total of 4283 places have been allocated to Victoria, including 934 places to Monash, 890 to Victoria University, 740 to RMIT, 652 to Deakin and 464 to Swinburne.

In NSW, 5935 extra places have been created, including 1084 at Charles Sturt University, 967 at the University of Newcastle, 936 at the University of Wollongong, 755 at Western Sydney University and 733 at the University of NSW.

The extra places will not be fee-free, unlike the 10,000 nursing and midwifery degrees the Victorian government promised to pay for in August.

Enrolments in teaching courses at Australian universities have fallen by 16 per cent in the past 10 years.

The former Morrison government attempted to attract more students into teaching through its sector-wide fee changes called Job Ready Graduates.

But a new analysis of these reforms has found they had minimal impact encouraging students to enrol in priority fields of study.

Maxwell Yong, an honours student at the University of Melbourne Graduate School of Education, analysed NSW Universities Admission

'This means more teachers, nurses and engineers.'

Jason Clare, Education Minister

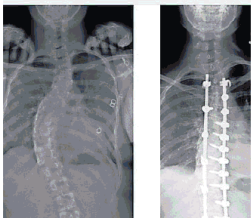
Centre data between 2014 and 2022 to examine the relationship between fees and study choices.

He found enrolments in nursing, teaching and agriculture – which had their fees cut by an average of 26 per cent under Job Ready Graduates – grew their enrolment share by just 0.88 per cent as a result of the policy.

The reforms delivered fee cuts of 17 per cent in IT and public health, 59 per cent in nursing and teaching, and 29 per cent in engineering. But university funding was also slashed under the changes, by 41 per cent for most of those fields.

Other areas including arts, communications, law and business, had fee increases of between 30 per cent and 117 per cent.

can flatten the curve



difficulty with children's breathing and their internal organs. Yang said only about 1 per cent of the population would develop scoliosis. Of that, only 10 per cent would require medical treatment such as bracing, which can stop the condition from worsening, or surgery to reduce the spinal curve.

Curvature of less than 20 degrees was considered mild and more than 40 to 50 degrees was considered severe. Mild cases may

not need any treatment if the patient wasn't expected to grow much more.

It was important that surgery wasn't delayed for the patients who needed it, Yang said.

"The surgery for a 60-degree curvature is very different to the surgeries for a 90-degree curvature," he said. "In some cases, patients may require multiple surgeries for something which required one surgery previously because their scoliosis has become more severe with time and growth. The surgeries can be more complicated and the outcomes worse."

Mel Venville first noticed her daughter's back "just didn't look right" when she was trying on clothes. She said Ella, now 15 and in year 10, appeared to have one side of her rib cage bigger than the other. The case was severe enough

to require surgery. Coincidentally, Ella's school friend, Scarlett Pope, had surgery a year earlier for a similar curve, which was affecting her breathing.

"I was shocked at how fast it happened. It was the blink of an eye. It wasn't as easy to breathe as my lungs were getting squashed," Scarlett said.

Epworth paediatric nurse unit manager Meredith Elliott said that while scoliosis operations were some of the more major planned procedures they conducted on children, the required hospital stay had drastically reduced during her career, from several weeks to three to five days.

Elliott said some people still might not be aware of the condition. "I walk around the supermarket and I see kids that I know have scoliosis," she said.

clash over energy

annuation funds to invest in a new energy company which the government owns."

Kennett told *The Australian Financial Review*: "This is the clearest indication we have seen yet that this Labor socialist premier is so totally irresponsible that he would put forward a political gimmick ahead of the needs of the community."

But Andrews said yesterday he believed energy was an essential, not a business, and it had been a mistake for the Kennett government to sell off the commission's

assets. He said his energy plan would benefit Victorians rather than private companies, which he said had made \$23 billion in profits since privatisation.

"Privatisation has failed. It's failed pensioners, it's failed families, it's failed Victorians," Andrews said. "The SEC is coming back, and it's going to be better than ever."

Opposition Leader Matthew Guy said the people of the Latrobe Valley did not want a return to the past. "They want to find something new, want a plan for the future."

Teen flung in air in shark attack

Ashleigh McMillan

A teenager has had a lucky escape after a large shark took a bite out of his surf ski while he was racing one kilometre offshore south-west of the Adelaide CBD.

Nathaniel Drummond, 19, was taking part in the South Australian Ocean Paddlers series at Seaciff Beach yesterday when he was flung out of his surf ski by a shark, which may have been a great white.

"My ski just kind of lifted above the water, and then the next thing I



Nathaniel Drummond; his surf ski.

knew I was in the air," he told *Nine News*. "Then I was in the water and I saw this figure just kind of fall back into the water – a big shark."

Drummond ripped his leg rope off after the attack and swam to

wards his fellow competitors, who helped him return to land.

While shaken, the 19-year-old was uninjured. His ocean ski now bears a gaping hole thanks to the shark's bite, which occurred directly underneath where the teen was sitting.

His parents watched on during the attack, hugging the boy tightly once he returned to the shore.

Claire Drummond said online she was thankful for the paddlers around her son who "just jumped in without any hesitation and pulled Nat to safety".